# Find Your Way Around

## THE FREEDAWM GUIDE



ONE PAGE, ONE IDEA:
CHEAT SHEETS FOR RECORDING, EDITING AND MIXING

FreeDAWm

# Welcome to FreeDAWm

## A free, open-source studio for recording, editing and mixing music, on the computer you already have.

FreeDAWm is a digital audio workstation. It runs on macOS, Windows, Linux and FreeBSD, and in a web browser.

You work in two main windows. The **Edit** window is the timeline, where you record, cut and arrange. The **Mix** window is the mixer, where you balance and shape the sound.

This guide is a binder of cheat sheets, not a manual to read from start to finish. Each page covers one idea, and most are a picture with labels.

Keep the page you need open beside FreeDAWm, or print it and pin it up.

### HOW TO READ A SHEET

- The lettered dots on a picture match the lettered notes under it.
- Keys look like this: `Cmd` `S`. Hold the first, press the second.
- On Windows, Linux and FreeBSD, press `Ctrl` wherever a sheet says `Cmd`.
- Menu items are written as a path: Setup › Keyboard Shortcuts.

The pictures show **Midnight Groove**, the demo song that comes with FreeDAWm, so your screen can match the page while you follow along.

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SECTION 1

# Getting Around

The two windows you will spend your time in, the four ways clips can move, and the keys worth learning first.

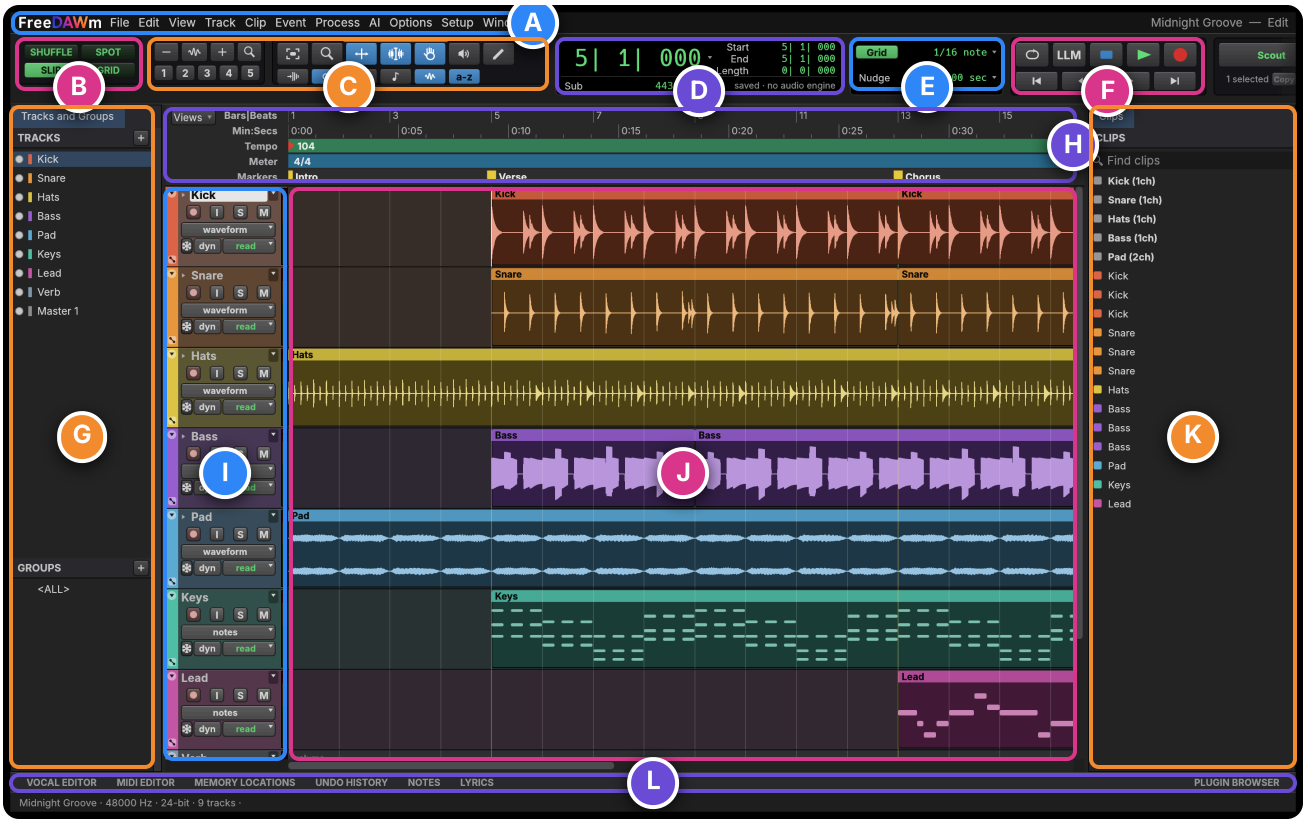
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# THE EDIT WINDOW

**The Goal**

Know what each part of the timeline window is for, so you can find a control without hunting. Open it with Window › Edit, or press Cmd = to flip between Edit and Mix.




**A — Menu bar**
Every command lives here. If you forget a key, look in the menus.

**B — Edit modes**
Shuffle, Slip, Spot and Grid decide how clips move when you drag them. See page 7.

**C — Zoom and tools**
Zoom buttons and five zoom presets, then the editing tools. See page 7.

**D — Counter**
Where the cursor is, and the start, end and length of your selection.

**E — Grid and Nudge**
The size of a grid step and of a nudge. Nudge with + and −.

**F — Transport**
Loop, stop, play and record on top, and the buttons that jump or wind underneath.

**G — Tracks and Groups**
Every track in the song. Click the dot beside a name to show or hide that track.

**H — Rulers**
Time in bars and in minutes, then tempo, meter and markers.

**I — Track controls**
Record, input monitor (I), solo (S) and mute (M), then the track's view and automation mode.

**J — Timeline**
Your clips. Audio is drawn as waveforms and MIDI as notes. Time runs left to right.

**K — Clips list**
Every clip in the session. Type in Find clips to search it.

**L — Panel tabs**
Click a tab to open the Vocal Editor, MIDI Editor, Undo History and more.

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# THE MIX WINDOW

**The Goal**

Read a channel strip from top to bottom. Sound enters at the top of a strip and leaves at the fader, so the order on screen is the order the sound travels.




**A** **Transport and counter**
The same play, stop and record controls as the Edit window.

**B** **Channel width**
Slim strips fit more on screen. Wide strips show each effect's knobs.

**C** **Effects**
EQ, compressors and the rest, processed from top to bottom. Click + to add one.

**D** **Sends**
Slots a to e each send a copy of the track somewhere else, often to a shared reverb.

**E** **I/O**
Where the track's sound comes from and goes to, then its automation mode.

**F** **Group and pan**
The knob places the sound left or right. Stereo tracks get one knob per side.

**G** **Strip buttons**
Input monitor, record and freeze, then solo (S) and mute (M).

**H** **Fader and meter**
The fader sets the track's level. The meter beside it shows how loud it is.

**I** **Level and name**
The fader's value in dB, the track type, and the track name.

**J** **Aux input**
Verb is an aux track. It takes whatever the other strips send to Verb.

**Good to know**

The list on the left is the same Tracks and Groups list as in the Edit window. The coloured bar under each name matches that track's clips on the timeline.

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# EDIT MODES & TOOLS

**The Goal**

The edit mode decides where a clip lands when you move it. The tool decides what a click or drag does. Pick both before you edit.

## THE FOUR EDIT MODES

BY HAND

### Slip
F2 or Alt+2



Clips go exactly where you drop them. Gaps and overlaps are allowed. This is the mode FreeDAWm starts in.

### Shuffle
F1 or Alt+1



Clips close up end to end. Cut a piece out and everything after it slides left to fill the gap.

### Spot
F3 or Alt+3




FreeDAWm asks for an exact position, and the clip goes there. Use it when you know the time and not the place.

### Grid
F4 or Alt+4



Clips and selections jump to the nearest grid line. Press F4 again for Relative Grid, which keeps a clip's offset from the line.

STAYS WHERE YOU PUT IT

SNAPS INTO PLACE

BY THE CLOCK

**Left and right:** does the clip stay where you put it, or does FreeDAWm line it up for you?

**Up and down:** do you place it by hand, or by a time on the ruler?

## THE TOOLS

- F5 **Zoomer** — Drag across an area to zoom in on it.
- F6 **Trim** — Drag a clip's edge to make it shorter or longer.
- F7 **Selector** — Click to place the cursor. Drag to select a range.
- F8 **Grabber** — Drag a clip to move it.
- F9 **Scrubber** — Drag over audio to hear it under the pointer.
- F10 **Pencil** — Draw notes and automation.

**Smart Tool**

Press F6 and F7 together for three tools in one. Near a clip's edge it trims, in the upper half of a clip it selects, and in the lower half it grabs.

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# KEYBOARD SHORTCUTS

**The Goal**

Learn these first. They cover most of a session, and each one saves a trip to the menus. On Windows, Linux and FreeBSD, press Ctrl wherever you see Cmd.

## PLAY AND RECORD

| | |
|---|---|
| Play or stop | Space |
| Record | F12 or Cmd Space |
| Play at half speed | Shift Space |
| Back to the start | Home |
| Go to the end | End |
| Add a marker | Enter |
| Loop playback on or off | Cmd Shift L |
| Play the selection | Alt [ |

## TRACKS

| | |
|---|---|
| New track | Cmd Shift N |
| Record enable | Shift R |
| Solo | Shift S |
| Mute | Shift M |
| Input monitoring | Shift I |
| Group tracks | Cmd G |

## SESSION

| | |
|---|---|
| New session | Cmd N |
| Open a session | Cmd O |
| Save | Cmd S |
| Save as | Cmd Shift S |
| Import audio | Cmd Shift I |
| Bounce the mix to a file | Cmd Alt B |

## EDITING

| | |
|---|---|
| Undo | Cmd Z |
| Redo | Cmd Shift Z |
| Cut, copy, paste | Cmd X C V |
| Duplicate | Cmd D |
| Select all | Cmd A |
| Split at the selection | Cmd E |
| Heal a split | Cmd H |
| Trim to the selection | Cmd T |
| Create fades | Cmd F |
| Mute a clip | Cmd M |
| Clear the selection | Cmd B or Delete |
| Nudge later or earlier | + − |

## ZOOM AND VIEW

| | |
|---|---|
| Zoom out or in | R T |
| Fit the whole session | Alt A |
| Zoom to the selection | Alt F |
| Zoom toggle | E |
| Jump to the next clip edge | Tab |
| Switch between Mix and Edit | Cmd = |
| Edit modes | F1 to F4 |
| Tools | F5 to F10 |

**Make them yours**

Change any shortcut in Setup › Keyboard Shortcuts. A few keys are fixed, including Space, Enter, Tab and the F keys.